



NEHWAL WORKING OUT
ON THE TREADMILL;
(RIGHT) IN TRAINING

EATING MEAT SO THAT SHE COULD HAVE THE STRENGTH OF A CHAMP.

“
Saina is
India’s most
complete
player. If she
concentrates
on her game,
she will
be the world
No. 1.”

**PRAKASH
PADUKONE**
FORMER BADMINTON
PLAYER

belt of champions and coaches, but Nehwal (one of the only two women of non-Chinese extraction in the top 10) has sensed an opening, particularly after Indonesia. The Chinese have power but, “they are also human, not machines who can keep running, you have to make them move.” She was told in turn that a Chinese website rated her as their toughest competitor at the Worlds.

She is flattered but sombre, “It is not easy to win against them... I have sacrificed so many things.” She wanted to be a doctor and Harvir, a Ph.D and agricultural scientist, found it odd when she had to miss exams to play instead. Now he says, “I look at it as if she is doing studies in sports.” He was offered a promotion in Delhi but turned it down as Nehwal’s badminton would have suffered. Usha denies herself favourite foods that her daughter does—icecream, chocolates, chaat, saying, “*Tum nahin toh hum bhi nahin*”. In China once, Gopichand told vegetarian Nehwal that she couldn’t be picky about food, that she had to eat meat, “if I wanted to be stronger than them”. So she simply switched.

Her focus is so unwavering, her ambition so uncompromising that Nehwal sometimes seems almost flinty. She has no friends on the world circuit, (“right now they feel, we have to beat her, we have to beat her”), thinks Facebook-ing is a waste of time and saw her last movie in December. She treats herself to a single ice-cream only after she wins an event. She seems the perfect poster girl for her hometown where work-in-progress sites cluster around hillsides of giant, unyielding rocks.

Yet she is also just a girl, an unusual one, who gives the smallest glimpses of her other self: cuddly-toy figures hanging from the zipper of her racket bag, coloured streaks in her hair, enjoying our photoshoot in a swirling Tarun Tahiliani dress (four-inch Fendis defeated her). She does think it would be cool to have a signature T-shirt, (some embroidery on the back, not a big ‘S’ for Supergirl on the front) but hankering for a ‘normal teenage’, girl-talk, ‘hanging out’ is swatted aside, “I love winning, you know. I love standing on a podium rather than going out for a cup of coffee.”

It is a daunting sense of mission. “It’s not easy to be a champion,” she shrugs. She has succeeded not merely because of her addiction (her word) to badminton, but also her appetite for the tough choice. Today, Gopichand says, Nehwal is at a stage where the choices are tougher because the margins became narrower. “If Saina plays 5 per cent better she will beat the top 8-10 players around her, if she is 5 per cent off her game, 20 more players can beat her.”

The air around is thin but Nehwal is enjoying the view and she even meditates for 45 minutes during events. Her coaches are surprised at how quickly she burst into the top 10; Indonesian Atik Jauhari, attached to the Indians for the Commonwealth Games, has a new target for her now, “The big five. After that... maybe the big one.”

To Gopichand, she feeds her hunger for victory not with dreaming, but work. As much as she loves winning, losing reveals her best.